Customer Discovery Process & Insights

POOLD - Preliminary findings from student interviews

Prepared for SENG 455 / BCOM 450 - Milestone 2 Proof of Concept

1. Purpose of Customer Discovery

Milestone 1 proposed POOLD as a community group-buying app for food and household essentials. At that stage, the team explicitly identified several assumptions about buyer behaviour, organizer behaviour, convenience, coordination, and product overlap that needed to be tested. Customer discovery for Milestone 2 was therefore used to confirm, challenge, or leave unresolved those assumptions and to identify the actual behaviours, barriers, trust concerns, and organizer risks that should shape the proof of concept.

Initial assumptions tested

- People are willing to coordinate with people they do not know.
- People are willing to pivot if an item is out of stock.
- People are willing to take initiative at creating groups.
- People are willing to wait on someone else's schedule.
- People's grocery orders have a large overlap.
- Savings are more important than convenience.
- People don't need messaging to coordinate.

2. Discovery Process

The team conducted 11 semi-structured interviews with university students between October 9 and October 11, 2026. Participants were treated as potential buyers, potential organizers, or both. The questionnaire first explored existing shopping behaviour before moving into bulk buying, purchase sharing, trust, and organizer experience.

Participants	11 university students; interview records describe participants primarily as students in their early 20s, with one age 27.
Interview dates	October 9-11, 2026
Topics covered	Current shopping habits; bulk buying; purchase sharing; trust in strangers; organizer experience.
Interview setting	[TO UPDATE: where / how interviews were conducted]
Recruitment rationale	[TO UPDATE: how participants were selected and why these interviewees were chosen]

2.1 Milestone 1 Assumptions: What the Interviews Suggest

The first interview round did not simply validate the idea. It produced a mixed picture: some assumptions were directionally supported, some were conditional, one was clearly challenged, and others still require direct testing in the MVP.

Milestone 1 assumption	Status after interviews	Evidence from discovery	Implication
People are willing to coordinate with people they do not know.	Partially supported / conditional	Several participants were open to strangers, while others preferred roommates or known people. Public/nearby pickup, trust, savings, and quality mattered.	Support verified university identity, public pickup, and invite-only groups instead of assuming universal stranger trust.
People are willing to pivot if an item is out of stock.	Not yet validated	The interview set produced little direct evidence about substitution behaviour because few participants had organized larger group orders.	Test out-of-stock and substitution choices in the MVP rather than assuming users will accept a pivot.

People are willing to take initiative at creating groups.	Challenged	Most interviewees were more willing to join than organize; only limited occasional organizer interest appeared.	Organizer supply is a critical risk. Minimize organizer work and test incentives.
People are willing to wait on someone else's schedule.	Partially supported / conditional	Several participants would join if pickup were nearby, safe, or already on their route; one specified roughly a 10-minute walk.	Scheduled pickup may work only when it is highly convenient. Test weekly vs monthly vs one-off timing.
People's grocery orders have a large overlap.	Directionally supported, not proven	Common staples repeated across interviews, including milk, eggs, chicken, rice, fruit, cereal, and toiletries.	There appears to be overlap, but the team still needs to measure whether enough people want the same product/brand/quantity at the same time.
Savings are more important than convenience.	Challenged	Cost mattered, but convenience, travel, storage, spoilage, and nearby pickup repeatedly influenced shopping decisions.	POOLD must balance savings with convenience; savings alone are unlikely to drive repeat use.
People don't need messaging to coordinate.	Not yet validated / potentially challenged	Current shared shopping often relies on group chats. Interviews show communication is already part of the workaround, but do not prove that in-app chat is required.	The MVP should test whether structured status updates and notifications are enough, rather than assuming communication can be removed.

3. Key Insights

1. Bulk purchasing already has value for many students

A majority of interviewees already buy some items in bulk. Common examples included meat/chicken, rice, eggs, toiletries, and other non-perishables. The most common reason was lower cost, followed by fewer restocking trips and splitting with roommates.

Product implication

Implication: POOLD does not need to create the idea of bulk buying; it needs to make bulk access more practical for people who do not want the entire package.

2. The problem is not only price - it is quantity, storage, and waste

Interviewees described barriers including upfront cost, limited fridge/freezer space, spoilage, having nobody to split with, and lacking a car or Costco membership. Several participants chose smaller packages because of consumption rate or spoilage, even when larger packs were cheaper.

Product implication

Implication: The value proposition should emphasize access to bulk economics while taking only the amount a user can realistically consume and store.

3. Shared purchasing already happens, but coordination is informal

Many interviewees live with roommates. Shared staples are often coordinated through group chats, followed by e-transfer and manual receipt splitting. Some participants rely on memory, Splitwise, or an honour system.

Product implication

Implication: A major substitute is not just another group-buying app; it is the combination of group chat + receipt + e-transfer. The MVP must reduce enough coordination work to justify switching.

4. Trust in unfamiliar participants is conditional

Some students were open to group buying with strangers, while others preferred roommates, friends, or known people. Conditions that improved willingness included a public pickup location, campus proximity, real savings, reliable portioning, and product quality.

Product implication

Implication: Verified university identity, public campus pickup, transparent savings, and the option for invite-only groups directly respond to interview concerns.

5. Organizer supply is the largest unresolved risk

No interviewee reported organizing group purchases beyond informal roommate trips. Most participants were more willing to use the app as members than as organizers. Only limited occasional organizer interest appeared, and suggested manageable group sizes were generally small.

Product implication

Implication: POOLD may attract joiners but fail if too few people organize. Organizer effort, risk, and incentives must be tested before scaling the concept.

4. How Discovery Changed the Product

The interviews influenced requirements and MVP priorities rather than serving only as validation. The strongest examples are summarized below.

Customer evidence	Product decision	Why it matters
Hesitation about strangers	Verified university email; invite-only or open groups	Builds trust without requiring every group to be public.
Campus/public pickup preferred	Organizer sets pickup location/time; public campus locations prioritized	Reduces safety and travel friction.
Manual receipt splitting/e-transfer	Automatic cost calculation and payment-status tracking	Removes repetitive administrative work.
Large packs create storage/spoilage issues	Members claim smaller shares of bulk packages	Connects the product directly to the quantity problem.
Potential organizers prefer small groups	Default group size around 6, configurable to 10	Keeps organizer workload closer to observed comfort levels.
Organizer time/upfront cost is a risk	Fast setup; explore pre-purchase collection and transparent compensation	Targets the largest viability risk found in discovery.

5. Biggest Risk Identified

Organizer bottleneck

The interviews showed stronger willingness to join than to organize. This is the most important assumption still requiring validation. The proof of concept should therefore test not only whether members can join an order, but whether the organizer workflow is fast and worthwhile enough that someone would repeat it.

6. Discovery Is Iterative and Continuing - Next Questions

- What would motivate more students to become organizers?
- Is organizer compensation necessary, and what type or amount feels reasonable?
- Do students prefer one-off orders, recurring weekly orders, or less frequent bulk runs?
- Will users accept substitutions or alternatives when an item is out of stock?

- Can structured order updates replace group-chat messaging, or is direct messaging still needed?
- How much real product overlap exists within the same week, including brand and package preferences?
- How much savings is enough to justify a scheduled pickup?
- Which trust mechanisms actually increase willingness to transact with unfamiliar students?
- Which product categories are best suited to an initial pilot?
- After using the MVP, is the process meaningfully easier than group chat + e-transfer?

7. Milestone 2 Validation Plan

The MVP will be used as a customer-discovery instrument. Potential members and organizers will be asked to complete the core group-creation and group-joining flows while the team observes usability, trust concerns, organizer effort, and perceived value. Feedback will be used to update requirements, personas, and backlog priorities for the next milestone.

Evidence standard for the next milestone

Interest in the idea is not enough. The next step is to observe whether users can complete the workflow, whether organizers would repeat it, and whether the experience meaningfully improves on current workarounds.